

Japanese Artist Finds Peace in Cutting Leaves

A Japanese artist who creates detailed designs on fallen leaves says the process gives the leaves new life and also helps keep him healthy.

The artist goes by the name Lito. He did not want to share his full name for personal reasons. Lito likes to cut, or carve, many different leaf designs. Examples of his work include a frog holding an umbrella, animals jumping happily, Japan's famous Mount Fuji and ocean waves.

This photo provided by Japanese artist Lito shows his work titled "Thirty-six Views of Mt. Fuji: The Great Wave off Kanagawa." (Lito via AP)

Lito began making his leaf art in 2020. Now, he has many fans around the world who discovered his designs on social media.

He recently told reporters from The Associated Press that his work also gives him peaceful feelings to help deal with a health issue. The condition Lito struggles with is called attention-deficit hyperactivity disorder, or ADHD. People with ADHD can experience difficulties such as mental focus, directing attention and organizing and controlling urges.

Japanese leaf-cutting artist, who goes by the name Lito, holds his freshly cut work featuring a frog with an umbrella, in Tokyo Wednesday, Nov. 27, 2024. (AP Photo/Shuji Kajiyama)

The 38-year-old Lito said that in addition to helping him deal with his own issues, he hopes his art can give other people enjoyment as well.

Lito likes working at night. In a demonstration of his process, he showed that he first treats several leaves with a chemical to keep them from drying out. Then, he chooses the one he wants to work on and places it on a cutting surface.

He begins by making a design on the leaf with a pen. He then uses a special design knife to cut the leaf. As he works slowly and carefully, one leaf begins to take the shape of a frog carrying an umbrella.

Japanese leaf-cutting artist, who goes by the name Lito, outlines on the leaf with a pen for his work in Tokyo Wednesday, Nov. 27, 2024. (AP Photo/Shuji Kajiyama)

Some of Lito's more complex creations on a single leaf can take more than eight hours to complete. He said he likes to finish a leaf in one sitting. His leaf-cutting works include titles such as Scrolls of Frolicking Animals, Leaf Aquarium, and Thirty-six Views of Mt. Fuji: The Great Wave off Kanagawa. He often uses animals as his subject and each piece includes some of his own personal elements.

This undated photo provided by Japanese leaf-cutting artist Lito shows his work titled "Choju Giga/Scrolls of Frolicking Animals."

Since his childhood, Lito says he has had high levels of concentration and patience. But no matter how hard he tried, he felt he could not meet expectations of behavior at school and work. He also struggled to understand others' feelings and to avoid conflict.

After years of difficulty, he went to a hospital at age 30 and was told he has ADHD, a diagnosis he felt explained why he has always done things differently.

Lito said he saw no reason to force himself to do things the same way as other people. So, he decided to change his way of living.

In early 2020, Lito learned about the art of leaf cutting. He saw it as the perfect use of his patience and concentration.

This undated photo provided by Japanese leaf-cutting artist Lito shows his work titled "Wait a second! That's my baby!"

Word of his skill has spread far across social media, and he has published books on his leaf-cutting work. And almost every month, he holds a showing of his art in different places in Japan.

"If I can make people happy by doing what I am doing, I want to do more. That's my driving force for what's next," Lito said.

I'm Jill Robbins.

Mayuko Ono, Shuji Kajiyama and Mari Yamaguchi reported this story for the Associated Press. Jill Robbins adapted it for Learning English.

Vocabulary

umbrella - n. ร่ม (อุปกรณ์ที่ใช้ป้องกันฝนหรือแสงแดด)

focus - n. สมาธิ, จุดสนใจ (ภาวะหรือสภาพที่ช่วยให้รับรู้หรือเข้าใจสิ่งต่างๆ ได้ชัดเจน)

concentration - n. สมาธิ, ความตั้งใจ (ความสามารถในการจดจ่อความสนใจหรือความคิดไปยังวัตถุหรือกิจกรรมเดียว)

patient - adj. ออดทน, ใจเย็น (การอดทนต่อความเจ็บปวดหรือความยากลำบากอย่างสงบหรือไม่บ่น)

diagnosis - n. การวินิจฉัยโรค (การค้นพบโรคทางการแพทย์)

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What two main benefits does the Japanese artist identify with his process of creating designs on fallen leaves?

It gives the leaves new life and helps keep him healthy.

It helps him earn money and gain fame.

It allows him to travel and meet new people.

It teaches him about different types of leaves and their properties.

2. What is the artist's chosen public name, and why does he prefer not to share his full name?

His name is Lito, and he wants to keep his identity mysterious.

His name is Lito, and he did not want to share his full name for personal reasons.

His name is Lito, and it is a common artist's practice in Japan.

His name is Lito, and his full name is too difficult to pronounce.

3. When did Lito begin making his leaf art, and how did he gain a global following?

He began in 2024, and his friends helped him spread the word.

He started in 2020, and he gained fans through local art exhibitions.

He began in 2020, and many fans around the world discovered his designs on social media.

He started in 2018, and art galleries promoted his work internationally.

4. What specific health condition does Lito suffer from, which his art helps him manage?

Attention-deficit hyperactivity disorder (ADHD).

Anxiety disorder.

Obsessive-compulsive disorder (OCD).

Depression.

5. According to the article, which of the following is NOT listed as a difficulty experienced by people with ADHD?

Mental focus.

Directing attention.

Organizing and controlling urges.

Physical coordination.

6. Besides helping himself, what other purpose does Lito hope his art serves for others?

He hopes his art can encourage other artists to try leaf carving.

He hopes his art can give other people enjoyment as well.

He hopes his art can raise awareness about ADHD.

He hopes his art can inspire people to protect the environment.

7. What is the first step Lito takes to prepare leaves for his artwork?

He draws a design on the leaf with a pen.

He chooses the perfect leaf from a collection.

He treats several leaves with a chemical to keep them from drying out.

He places the leaf on a cutting surface.

8. After designing on the leaf with a pen, what tool does Lito use to create the final shape?

A pair of scissors.

A laser cutter.

A special design knife.

A standard craft blade.

9. How long can some of Lito's more intricate leaf creations take to complete?

Less than an hour.

Approximately three to four hours.

More than eight hours.

A full day or more.

10. Which of the following is NOT mentioned as a common subject or element in Lito's leaf-cutting works?

Animals.

Famous landmarks other than Mount Fuji.

Ocean waves.

His own personal elements.

11. What two personal qualities did Lito possess since childhood, even though he struggled with social expectations?

High levels of creativity and innovation.

Excellent communication and social skills.

High levels of concentration and patience.

Strong leadership and organizational abilities.

12. At what age did Lito receive a formal diagnosis for his condition?

Age 20.

Age 30.

Age 38.

He never received a formal diagnosis.

13. After his diagnosis, what significant decision did Lito make regarding his life?

He decided to seek intensive therapy to change his behavior.

He decided to force himself to do things the same way as other people.

He decided to change his way of living.

He decided to stop pursuing any artistic endeavors.

14. When did Lito discover leaf cutting, and what did he see in it regarding his personal strengths?

In late 2019, seeing it as a way to challenge his weaknesses.

In early 2020, seeing it as the perfect use of his patience and concentration.

In mid-2021, seeing it as a casual hobby.

In late 2022, seeing it as a potential source of income.

15. Beyond gaining popularity on social media, what other ways has Lito shared his leaf-cutting work with the public?

He has published books and holds monthly art showings in Japan.

He sells his work exclusively through online auctions.

He only displays his art in private collections.

He teaches leaf-cutting workshops at local community centers.